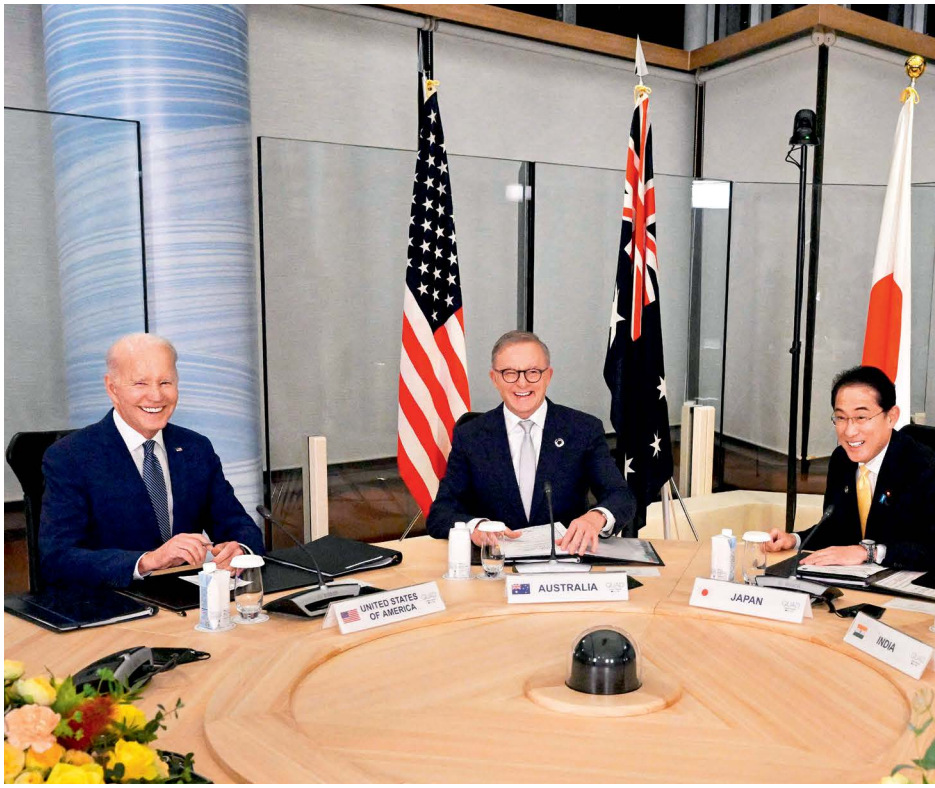


GETTY IMAGES

MODI IS LEVERAGING THE PRESIDENCY OF THE G20 AND SCO THIS YEAR TO ENSURE INDIA HAS A PERMANENT PLACE AT THE GLOBAL HIGH TABLE

Kant. "Today, we are number one. In terms of digital transactions, we are doing 11 times more than what the US and Europe combined are doing, and four times more than China. That is the revolution Prime Minister Modi has brought about on the digital front. This is what he meant by minimum government, maximum governance."

Infrastructure, particularly road construction, too, saw a major push in Modi's first term. Under his go-getter roads minister Nitin Gadkari, 50,000 km of highways were constructed in the first five years alone compared to 25,718 km during Manmohan Singh's decade-long prime ministership.

MESSIAH OF THE POOR

It may seem appropriate to treat Modi's nine-year reign as a continuum, as many of the major programmes he began in his first term fructified in his second. But it is important to segregate the two terms and assess them separately. In the first term, Modi's style of leadership was akin to Indira Gandhi's, including taking decisive and far-reaching economic and political decisions that disrupted the status quo even while staying hard-focused on addressing the plight of India's poor. If Indira Gandhi took the drastic step of resorting to bank nationalisation to alleviate poverty, Narendra Modi pushed for the centralisation of taxes and ushered in the Goods and Services Tax (GST) regime to rationalise and enhance revenue collection and stimulate economic growth.

Again, like Indira Gandhi declared national emergency in 1975, ostensibly to quell the Opposition, which she claimed was blocking development schemes for the poor, Modi triggered a financial emergency when overnight he enforced the demonetisation of high-value currency notes in November 2016. The draconian measure, he claimed, was necessary to rid India of black money and clean up the corrupt political system. Even as he apologised for the hardships his move caused the poor, especially the endless queues they had to endure to exchange money at the banks, he couched it in patriotic terms, saying the people of India did not mind suffering hardship if it was for a greater good. He also said his intentions were honest, only the implementation was lagging. However, unlike Indira Gandhi, who lost the election in 1977, Modi retained his electoral fortunes.

Both Indira Gandhi, with her Garibi Hatao slogan, and Modi, with his focus on the *saadhaaran manav*, have cast themselves as messiahs of the poor via their massive welfare schemes. They have also been lauded for their gutsy decisions on the national security front—Indira Gandhi for crafting the victory in the 1971 Bangladesh war and Modi for carrying out surgical strikes after the Uri attacks in 2017 and conducting air strikes deep inside Pakistan after the attack on Pulwama in 2019. The last decision was to turn the tide in favour of Modi again in the 2019 general election, which his party won by a convincing majority. Indira Gandhi had to wait three years before storming back to power in 1980 following her ouster after Emergency.

FIREFIGHTING ON ALL FRONTS

In his second term, Modi would be confronted by a polycrisis of a magnitude that only Nehru possibly had to handle after taking over as India's first prime minister. Partition had plunged the country into a dire economic crisis following the enormous disruption in the movement of goods and services. Then, he had to unite the warring states that were at the time nothing more than a loose conglomeration of administrative provinces and princely kingdoms. Meanwhile, he had to thwart the Pakistan-directed tribal invasion to capture Kashmir and fashion a non-aligned foreign policy to ensure India kept equal distance from the world's two